NORDLAND

Case record

Nordland is a fictional country. The facts below are the complete record for this exercise; treat them as true. Do not supply additional facts about Nordland, and do not draw on information about any real place with the same or a similar name.

Record definitions and scope

The record concerns Nordland's nationwide universal benefit system as a whole; no benefit subprogram breakdown is supplied. A claim is a filed benefit application. Denial rates refer to initial agency determinations before any appeal; the record does not report appeal outcomes or allow identification of repeated claims by a person.

"Minority background" is an aggregate grouping in the benefit and resident-survey figures; "other" denotes the comparison group. The record does not specify the component identities. The resident survey samples residents, the office table counts claims, the notice trial enrolls claimants by registered home language, and the hiring audit samples fictitious résumés. These data sources are not person-level linked; the record does not state that their group labels identify identical individuals.

Founding and design

1. Nordland's universal benefit system was established between 1948 and 1956 through an agreement between the national labor federation and the smallholders' party. Its founding charter describes the system's purpose as "the common security of every working household." Eligibility does not depend on citizenship. It requires two years of registered residence, and applicants must document their income for the 24 months before applying.

Outcomes and public opinion

2. Poverty (2025). Before taxes and transfers, 23% of residents had incomes below the national poverty line; after taxes and transfers, 7%. Among residents of minority background, the figures were 34% before and 13% after.

3. National Social Survey (2025; probability sample, n = 6,100). Agreement with "The benefit system is good for Nordland": 76% of minority respondents, 79% of other respondents. Agreement with "I feel fully part of Nordland society": 52% of minority respondents, 81% of other respondents. About one third of minority-background respondents were born in Nordland; among them, 74% agreed with the second statement, compared with 41% of minority-background respondents born abroad.

4. International reputation. Internationally, Nordland is generally known as a high-welfare state that takes great care of its residents; a 2025 international index of social protection ranked it third of 38 high-income countries. It is also generally known for failing in the area of minority protections; a 2024 periodic review by an international human rights treaty committee found its protections for minority residents inadequate.

5. Website poll (2025). An optional satisfaction survey on the benefits agency's website (n = 1,240; respondents self-selected) reports that 88% were satisfied with "the service I received."

Benefit decisions

6. Denial rates (2025, all claims). Minority-background applicants file approximately 20% of all claims. Their claims were denied at a rate of 18.3%; claims by other applicants, at 8.9%. About one third of minority-background claims are filed by applicants born in Nordland; their claims were denied at 11.0%, compared with 21.9% for minority-background applicants born abroad.

7. Office type. Six of Nordland's 16 benefit offices use discretionary eligibility interviews; the other ten decide claims on documents alone. Table A1 gives the figures for each office. Interview offices receive 45% of claims filed by minority-background applicants and 30% of other claims. Denial rates in interview offices: 24.7% for minority-background claims, 10.2% for other claims. Denial rates in document-only offices: 13.1% for minority-background claims, 8.4% for other claims.

8. Documentation. When filed, 25% of applications at interview offices are incomplete (missing one or more required documents), compared with 14% at document-only offices. By group, 26% of minority-background applications are incomplete when filed, compared with 16% of other applications.

Table A1. Benefit offices, 2025

Office	Discretionary interviews	Claims	Minority share of claims	Denial: minority	Denial: other	Incomplete at filing
Office 1	No	14,000	13%	11.1%	8.2%	13%
Office 2	Yes	11,000	29%	26.2%	10.7%	26%

Office	Discretionary interviews	Claims	Minority share of claims	Denial: minority	Denial: other	Incomplete at filing
Office 3	No	12,500	16%	12.0%	8.5%	14%
Office 4	No	9,000	11%	11.7%	8.0%	12%
Office 5	Yes	9,500	27%	25.6%	10.0%	25%
Office 6	No	8,500	31%	21.5%	9.0%	24%
Office 7	Yes	8,000	25%	26.9%	10.4%	27%
Office 8	No	11,000	15%	11.2%	8.6%	13%
Office 9	Yes	7,500	32%	24.7%	9.8%	25%
Office 10	No	10,000	17%	11.9%	8.3%	14%
Office 11	No	8,000	13%	10.8%	8.1%	12%
Office 12	Yes	6,500	18%	11.2%	9.6%	21%
Office 13	No	10,500	19%	11.8%	8.7%	14%
Office 14	No	9,000	14%	11.1%	8.4%	13%
Office 15	Yes	7,000	29%	26.7%	10.3%	26%
Office 16	No	8,000	18%	11.8%	8.5%	15%

Additional benefit-decision evidence

9. Employment histories. Of incomplete applications, 61% come from applicants with irregular employment histories (no single employer for 12 consecutive months in the prior two years). Of complete applications, 23% do.

10. Translated notices (randomized trial, 2025). In five offices, 5,200 claimants whose registered home language is a minority language were randomly assigned to receive eligibility notices either in their home language or in the national language (the standard practice). Denial rates: 15.2% with translated notices, 19.6% with standard notices. In the same offices and period, the denial rate for claimants whose home language is the national language was 9.3%.

11. Software change. In January 2025 the agency moved to new case-management software. For the following two months, denial rates for all claimants rose by about one percentage point, then returned to their previous levels.

12. Caseworker posts. In March 2026 a national newspaper published social-media posts in which a caseworker made disparaging remarks about minority applicants. The caseworker worked at a document-only office and was dismissed after an internal review.

Employment

13. Hiring audit (2024). Researchers sent 4,800 résumés to advertised jobs across Nordland in matched pairs, identical except for the applicant's name. Résumés with minority-associated names received callbacks 7.1% of the time; résumés with majority-associated names, 11.6%. In the areas served by the four offices with the smallest differences between minority and other claimants' denial rates (Table A1), the callback rates were 6.9% and 11.2%.

History

14. Assimilation policy. Archival records show that from 1931 to 1969, national policy required schooling exclusively in the national language and required land and residence registrations to be filed under national-language names or with certified translations.

15. Present-day effects. Two recent scholarly assessments reach different conclusions. One historian (2022) argues that the policy's effects on minority families' records and on their trust in public agencies continue today. Another (2023) argues that those effects largely ended after reforms in the 1970s and that present disparities reflect current conditions.

Essay assignment

> Read the Nordland case record. In an analytical essay of no more than 1,500 words, identify the most important questions the record raises, examine what the evidence suggests about the welfare system, and explain which conclusions can be justified and why. The essay may use prose, charts, tables, diagrams, graphics, prioritizations, or other representations, alone or in combination, to communicate the analysis—including non-linear or overlapping relationships. No particular presentation format is required. Any text within these representations counts toward the word limit.